

serious when I play him," he says. "What I aspire to bring is not to lose sight of the vulnerability and what drove him into this situation in the first place. Vikrant has visions of being James Bond but has no idea how to go about it. You know he is going to mess it up. There's this saying—either you die a hero or you see yourself go onto a darker side. That's what happens to him."

One of Netflix's surprise hits back in 2022, *Yeh Kaali Kaali Aankhein* is back after nearly three years. That brought its own set of challenges for the cast and crew as there was no narrative leap as they returned to work. It meant that Bhasin had to lose the seven kilograms he had gained to shoot another show. "I have seen a number of series which have taken time to come out with a season two. I believe you reconnect with the character if the look is the same," he says. Bhasin consciously didn't rewatch season one, relying instead on the script and the backstory he had created to flesh Vikrant out.

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One look at Bhasin's Wikipedia profile and one can see that he's perhaps one of the more overeducated artists in the field. There's a political science degree from Delhi University, a master's in media from Australia; thespian credits include stints with Barry John, Naseeruddin Shah and more. "Education never goes to waste," says Bhasin. "It gives an added worldview and insight when you read a script—the broader your canvas, the more you can bring to a part." His short but fascinating oeuvre thus far offers glimpses of his approach. From a breakthrough role as an antagonist in *Mardaani*, he has gone on to play Sunil Gavaskar (*83*), '50s star Shyam (*Manto*) and a brooding, cool collegian (*Chhichhore*).

But it's with Vikrant that Bhasin finds himself having a "complete arc", which, he admits, is "rare" to get. It's why he cannot wait to get into the character's twitchy shoes again. Even as Netflix is poised to greenlight season three given the show has avoided "the curse of season two", Bhasin hopes Sengupta "doesn't take as long as he did" to progress the story. After all, it's the good things that you want the soonest. ■

–Suhani Singh

Mirza, a Canadian writer, director and producer of Pakistani origin, on board as a co-writer. "Working with Fawzia was so wonderful because of what it signified: two queer filmmakers—from India and Pakistan—coming together to write stories of inclusion," says Onir. Then, right before the film's Indian premiere at the Dharamshala Film Festival, acclaimed filmmaker Deepa Mehta boarded the film as a presenter, a development that made the whole experience even more fulfilling for Onir.

Still, the journey to make the film hasn't always been smooth. Initially, the love story at the heart of *We Are Faheem & Karun* was meant to be told from the perspective of a gay soldier, a character inspired by a real-life major who quit the Indian Army on account of his sexual orientation. In 2022, when Onir sent across the script to the ministry of defence (a proposal introduced in 2020 made it mandatory for the ministry to approve films made about the military), it was swiftly rejected. Not one to give up, Onir adapted to the unfortunate reality, substituting the gay soldier in his script to a gay security guard who falls in love with a Kashmiri man in the film.

Once he got that out of the way, Onir felt he had nothing to lose. *We Are Faheem & Karun* became less of a film and more of a passion project. "This is the first film in my career that is fully financed, directed and produced by me," he says. "I have spent all my resources to make this film." The filmmaker felt brave enough to take a couple more creative calls: Instead of shooting the film in Urdu, he chose to make it in Kashmiri. To add authenticity to his depiction of the milieu, he had Kashmiri actors play Kashmiri characters. More importantly, he relied on two newcomers to portray the lead couple in the film and, to his credit, got emotionally layered performances out of them.

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But Onir is already looking ahead. Meant to be a spiritual successor to *I Am* (2010), an anthology of four short films that shared a common theme, Onir plans to make four features under the *We Are...* umbrella. "The protagonists of the next three films are going to be transgender, lesbian and bisexual characters," he says. If anything, the filmmaker still doesn't wear his calling as the chronicler of queer Indians lightly. ■

–Poulomi Das